

RUTH

PREFACE.

This Book is called Ruth, from the name of the person whose history is here recorded; who, being a Gentile, became a convert to the true faith, and marrying Booz, the great-grandfather of David, was one of those from whom Christ sprang according to the flesh, and an illustrious figure of the Gentile church. It is thought this book was written by the prophet Samuel. Ch. --- The Holy Ghost chose that the genealogy of David, and of the Messias, should be thus more clearly ascertained. Theodoret. --- Christ proceeded from the Gentiles, as well as from the Jews, and his grace is given to both. W. --- Send forth, O Lord, the lamb, the ruler of the earth, from Petra.

Isai. xvi. This was the capital city of Arabia Petrea, where Ruth is supposed to have lived, (Tostat) being, according to the Chal. &c. the daughter of Eglon, king of Moab. The Jews also pretend that Booz was the same person as Abesan, the judge. But it is by no means certain to what period this history belongs. Usher places it under Samgar, about 120 years after Josue. C.

--- Salien believes that the famine, which obliged Elimelech to leave Bethlehem, happened under Abimelech, and that Noemi returned in the 7th year of Thola, A.C. 1243. This event certainly took place under some of the judges; so that we may consider this book as an appendix to the preceding, like the last chapters, (Judg. xvii. &c. H.) and a preface to the history of the kings. C.

RUTH 1

CHAPTER I.

Ver. 1. Of one. Heb. "And it came to pass in the days when the judges ruled."

H. --- The and shews the connection with the former book. C. --- Land. Chal.

adds, "of Israel," (M.) while the less fertile country of Moab had abundance.

God thus punished the idolatry of his people. Some say the famine lasted ten years; but this is uncertain, though Noemi continued so long out of the country, v. 4. Salien.

Ver. 2. Elimelech. Josephus and others read erroneously, Abimelech. He was probably called also Jokim. 1 Par. iv. 22. --- Ephrathites. This title often designates people of the tribe of Ephraim; (Judg. xii. 5. 1 K. i. 2,) but here it means those of Ephrata, which is also called Bethlehem of Juda, about five or six miles south of Jerusalem. Gen. xxxv. 19. Mic. v. 2. C.

Ver. 4. Ruth was the wife of Mahalon; (C. iv. 10,) and signifies one "well watered, (M.) or inebriated," &c. H. --- The sons of Noemi were excused by necessity in marrying idolaters, though they ought to have done their best to convert them. The Chaldee greatly condemns their marriage, and thinks that their death was in punishment of their prevarication. Deut. vii. 3. and xx. 11. C.

--- Salien is of the same opinion. So various have always been the sentiments of people on this head! H. See Serarius, q. 11.

Ver. 8. Mothers, who had separate apartments from the men. C. --- Me. They had behaved with great respect and love towards their husbands, and towards Noemi, whom they even wish to accompany. M. --- The pronouns in this, and verses 9, 11, 13, and 19, are surprisingly corrupted in Heb. being masculine or feminine, where we should expect the contrary. Kennicott.

Ver. 9. Take. She proposes marriage to them, as a state more suitable to their years, (H.) and wishes that they may experience none of its solitudes, (1 Cor.

vii. 28,) but be constantly protected by their husbands. Widows are exposed to many difficulties. M.

Ver. 11. Of me. Hence it appears that the Rabbins are under a mistake, when they say that those children who are born after the death of their brothers, are not obliged to take their widows.

Ver. 13. Marry. Heb. "would you stay for them from having husbands!"

Ver. 14. And returned, is not expressed in Heb. But the Sept. have, "and she returned to her people." H..

Ver. 15. To her gods, &c. Noemi did not mean to persuade Ruth to return to the false gods she had formerly worshipped; but by this manner of speech, insinuated to her, that if she would go with her, she must renounce her false gods, and turn to the Lord, the God of Israel. Ch. --- She wished to try her constancy. Salien. --- Most infer from this passage, that Orpha was never converted, or that she relapsed. --- Her gods, may indeed be rendered in the singular, "god." But what god was peculiar to her and the Moabites, but Chamos! C. --- Noemi might well fear that Orpha would give way to the superstition of her countrymen, to which she had been addicted, even though she might have made profession of serving the true God, while she lived with her.

H.

Ver. 17. The Lord do so and so, &c. A form of swearing usual in the history of the Old Testament, by which the person wished such and such evils to fall upon them, if they did not do what they said. Ch. --- It is not certain that they expressed what particular evils. C. --- They might be willing to undergo any punishment, if they should transgress. H. --- The pagans used a similar form of imprecation. 3 K. xix. 4 K. xx. 10. C.

Ver. 19. That Noemi. This exclamation might proceed either from surprise, or from contempt.

M.

Ver. 20. That is. The explanations are added by S. Jerom. H. --- Noemi had formerly a husband and two sons, with great riches, of which she was now deprived. W.

Ver. 21. Almighty. Heb. Sadai, ("the self-sufficient) hath afflicted."

Ver. 22. Harvest. About the month of Nisan, or our March (C.) and April. M.

RUTH 2

CHAPTER II.

Ver. 1. Booz. The Scripture does not specify how nearly they were related. R.

Josue says Elimelech, Salmon, and Tob (C. iii. 13,) were brothers, and Booz was the son of Salmon, which cannot be refuted, (Serar. q. 1. M.) though the authority and proofs be very weak. It is not, however, more probable that Booz was the brother of Elimelech. Some think that he was not the immediate son of Salmon, as four persons seem too few to fill up the space of 366 years, from the marriage of Rahab till the birth of David. But this is not impossible. C. See C. iv. 20.

Ver. 2. To me. It was the privilege of the poor and of strangers to glean. Deut.

xxiv. 19. Lev.

xix. 9. Yet Ruth asks leave, through civility. C. --- This law is no longer in force, but it would be inhuman for the rich to deny this liberty to those who are in distress, and willing rather to work than to beg. T.

Ver. 4. With you. This blessing the Church still adopts in her service. W. --- It was customary to bless one another during harvest. Ps. cxxviii. 5. 8. C. ---

Booz did, as Cato advises, Ne opera parcas visere; "See what is going forward." The master's eye makes the servants diligent. H.

Ver. 5. Man. Heb. nahar, a man in the prime of life. He had the care of all in the field, during the absence of his master; whence Josephus styles him agrocomos, or agronomos. M. --- Homer mentions an officer or king, standing with his sceptre in the midst of the reapers, and silently rejoicing at the rich profusion of the field. Iliad. --- Thus we see the taste of the ancients, while agriculture was honourable.

Ver. 7. Moment. Heb. "her tarrying in the house is but small, or till now, that she remains a little in the house." She entered the house with the reapers, during the excessive heat of the day, and to avoid the suspicion of taking more than was allowed, during their absence. C. --- Sept. "she hath not discontinued to work in the field even a little." Her diligence and modesty attracted the notice of Booz. H.

Ver. 9. Thee. The men tied the corn after the female reapers, (C.) and Ruth was authorized to follow, close at their heels, without fear. H. --- The waters. This is not expressed in Heb. but it is in the Sept. and the Chal. C. --- The privilege of having water in those countries was very considerable. M.

Ver. 10. Country. S. Elizabeth was impressed with similar sentiments, when she was visited by the blessed Virgin; (H.) and so was David, when he considered the wonderful condescension of God. Ps. viii. 5. cxliii. 3. Job vii. 17. C. ---

Frequent instances occur in Scripture of people worshipping, or shewing their gratitude to their fellow creatures, by this posture of the body. M.

--- Yet no suspicion of idolatry attaches to them. Gen. xxiii. 7. &c. H.

Ver. 11. Heretofore, to embrace the same religion. M.

Ver. 12. Work. Booz doubted not but a full and eternal reward was due to good works. W. ---

Fled. This similitude frequently occurs, (Ps. xxxv. 8. Mat. xxiii. 37,) to denote protection. C. ---

Chal. "Thou art come to be a proselyte, and to hide thyself under the shade of the majesty of his glory." M.

Ver. 13. Heart. This has the same meaning as the former part of the sentence.

C. See Ose. ii.

14. H. --- Maids, but more lowly and mean. M.

Ver. 14. Vinegar, or small wine, made on purpose for working people. Some think that such was presented to our Saviour. Yet vinegar was very frequently mixed with other things, and was esteemed particularly refreshing. Plin. xxiii.

1. C. --- Side. Not in front, that they might not stare at her. M. --- And she, &c.

Heb. "and he gave her frumenty, or parched corn." A little oil might be poured upon it. See Lev. ii. 14. 2 K. xxvi. 28. H. --- Travellers in Ethiopia only take parched barley with them. C. --- The leavings, to Noemi. "Learn, says Seneca, (ep. 110,) to be content with a little." Sept. "and Booz heaped up food before her, and she ate and was filled, and left a part. " H. --- But it appears that she afterwards took it home, v. 18. M. --- The vinegar and corn which were given to Ruth were very refreshing. The Spaniards still drink posca, or water and vinegar. T.

Ver. 15. Reap. Heb. "if she will glean, even among the sheaves, do not cover her with confusion," (H.) or hinder her. Ps. xliii. 10. C.

Ver. 17. Rod, as Gedeon had done. Judg. vi. 11. --- That is, &c. an explanation of the Vulg. C.

--- The ephi contained three pecks and three pints. Arbuthnot. --- Alcazar and A. Lapide say 960

ounces. M.

Ver. 20. Dead. He hath not forgotten Elimelech, his friend, for whose sake he treats his daughter-in-law with kindness. H. --- Kinsman. Heb. adds, "one of our redeemers, (C.) or next kinsmen." H. --- To such the right of avenging the slain, of marrying the widow of the deceased, and entering upon his property, belonged. The best interpreters suppose that Booz was the nephew of Elimelech. C. Lev. xxv. 25. Deut. xxv. 5. M.

Ver. 23. And the wheat. Heb. Syr. and Arab. " It is good that thou keep close to the maidens of Booz, and continue to glean with them till," &c. This was the advice of Noemi: but Providence ordered that Ruth should be married to Booz before the commencement of the wheat harvest. C.

--- The Prot. agree with the Vulg. and Sept. "So she kept fast by, &c. unto the end of the barley harvest, and of the wheat harvest, and dwelt with her mother-in-law." These last words are expressed by the Vulg in the following chapter.

H..

RUTH 3

CHAPTER III.

Ver. 1. I will. Heb. and Sept. may be read with an interrogation in the same sense. "Shall I not seek rest?" H. --- By this expression she means a husband.

C. i. 9. Marriage fixes the unsettled condition of women. C. --- Noemi being apprised of the law, entertained hopes that she could engage Booz to marry Ruth. H. --- Thus her penury would cease, and she would perhaps have children, as she earnestly desired. M.

Ver. 2. Night. In Palestine, and other maritime countries, a breeze generally arises from the sea in the evening. It was then that Booz seized the opportunity of winnowing his barley; so that, at an early hour, he gave Ruth six measures, and retired to rest, beside some of the remaining sheaves (C.) in an adjoining apartment, erected for the

protection of the reapers during the great heats, and to contain the corn in case of a shower. Columella, i. 7. and ii. 51.

This shade was probably in the same field where Ruth had been gleaning. C.

--- She might lawfully seize this opportunity (H.) to obtain an honest marriage.

D.

Ver. 3. Garments. External cleanliness has many attractions. Judith x. 3. Many editions of the Heb. are very confused, by the improper insertion of i: "I will put the garments on thee, and get me down, " &c. Ken.

Ver. 4. Sleepeth. People of fortune did not disdain to sleep among the corn.

Non pudor in stipula placidam cepisse quietem,

Nec fœnum capiti supposuisse suo. Ovid, Fast. i. M.

--- Feet. It is said that women in the East, enter their husbands' bed at the feet, to shew their submission. C. --- Ruth was conducted on this occasion by a superior Being, who gave success to her undertaking, and disposed the mind of Booz (Theodoret) to grant her just claim. It was according to the law of Moses, that a widow might demand in marriage the next kinsman of her deceased husband, if she had no children by him. Ruth considered Booz in this light. H. --- She was not actuated by a love of pleasure, as the latter was convinced, otherwise she would have desired to marry some young man, (C.) in her own country, v. 10. Both parties would probably have their clothes on among the straw, so that there would be less danger; though, if their virtue had not been very constant, (H.) the situation was no doubt sufficiently perilous, and in other circumstances could not have been tolerated. C. --- We must also remember, that clandestine marriages were not then forbidden. Salien. --- That same night they might have married, had not another's

being nearer akin proved an obstacle; (T.) so that Booz could not have claimed the inheritance of Elimelech, though he might have taken Ruth to wife. By deferring another day he obtained both. H. --- Lyranus thinks Ruth could be excused only by ignorance, in thus exposing herself to danger, and that Noemi was guilty of a grievous sin, in giving her such advice. But they both had the purest views, seeking only an honest marriage, by arts which were not blamable. See S. Tho.

2. 2. q. 154. and 169. and Cajet. T. --- Noemi was well assured of the virtue of both parties, and followed the directions of the Holy Spirit, (C.) as the event shewed. W.

--- Dr. Watson justly reproves the censure of Paine, who calls Ruth, "a strolling country girl, creeping slyly to bed to her cousin," and exclaims, "pretty stuff indeed to be called the word of God!" But in correcting this impertinent remark, he seems to allow that some things have been inserted in the Scriptures by human authority, so as not to be the word of God. This concession is more dangerous than the censure of Paine, and the quotation from S. Aug. by no means countenances it, as it barely insinuates that an express revelation was not requisite to insert some things, which the authors might know by other means. The holy father never doubted but every part of Scripture was equally inspired, and to be received without the smallest hesitation. What Dr. Law, and other such "good Christians," might think, does not regard us. H. --- "As a person imploring protection, Ruth laid herself down at the foot of an aged kinsman's bed, and she rose up with as much innocence as she laid herself down. She was afterwards married to Booz, and reputed by all her neighbours as a virtuous woman; and they were more likely to know her character than you are. Whoever reads the Book of Ruth, bearing in mind the simplicity of ancient manners, will find it an interesting story of a poor young woman," &c. Watson, let. 4. ---

Must do. She trusted to the superior wisdom of Booz, knowing perhaps that he was not absolutely the nearest relation, but being convinced, as the event proved, that the other would not consent to marry Ruth on the conditions specified by the law. Salien, A. 2810.

Ver. 7. Merry. Heb. "good," yet by no means intoxicated. D. M. --- It was formerly the custom, as it is still in many places, (H.) to conclude the harvest with a feast; (C.) on which day Cato observes, that the men and oxen did not work. De re Rust. c. 131. Hence the vacuna of Ovid. Fast. vi. T. --- The pagans did this in honour of Jupiter and Ceres. But the true God had enjoined his people (H.) to offer the first-fruits to him, and to feast in his presence. Lev.

xxiii. 10.

Deut. xxvi. 21. --- Sheaves, either of corn or of straw. Sept. --- The Arabs and neighbouring nations still delight to rest upon the ground, with some clothes thrown over them. C.

Ver. 8. Troubled. Heb. may be rendered, "and turned himself, or felt," &c. C. ---

He perceived something at his feet, when he awoke, and was in consternation, particularly when he perceived, through the glimmering light, a woman at his feet. H..

Ver. 9. Kinsman. Heb. "a redeemer;" (C.) one bound to defend and to espouse a brother's widow, if others more nearly akin refuse. H. --- Ruth modestly admonishes him of this duty, and begs that he would take her to wife, (C.) as he might then have done without any other formality.

Serar. q. vii. --- We find a similar expression, Ezec. xvi. 8. Deut. xxii. 80. Some think that she only asked for protection. The custom of the husband, stretching a part of his garment over his bride, was perhaps already established among the Hebrews. C. --- Heb. and Sept. "stretch thy wing over,"

&c. Chal. "Let thy name be invoked upon thy handmaid, to take me to wife." M.

Is.

iv. 1.

Ver. 10. Thy latter kindness; viz. to thy husband deceased, in seeking to keep up his name and family, by marrying his relation according to the law, and not following after young men: for Booz, it seems, was then in years. Ch. --- Salien supposes about seventy years old. H. --- The affection which Ruth had all along displayed towards her husband, deserved applause. C. ---

Much more did her present endeavours to comply with God's law. W.

Ver. 11. Woman. Virtuous here may denote, "strong, generous," &c. Prov. xxxi.

10. C. --- But it includes the assemblage of all virtues. H.

Ver. 12. Than I. The Jews think that he was brother of Elimelech, while Booz was only his nephew. But they might be in the same degree; the other being only older. C.

Ver. 13. Well. Heb. tob. H. --- Hence the Jews would translate, "If Tob will redeem thee, let him." They say that Tob was the paternal uncle of Mahalon: but it is not probable that his proper name should be only here mentioned, and not C. iv. The Sept. and Chaldee are conformable to the Vulg. and the opinion of the Jews is abandoned by most interpreters; (C.) and by the Prot.

"well, let him do the kinsman's part." H. --- Liveth. Chal. "Bound by an oath, before the Lord, I say that I will fulfil my promise unto thee."

Ver. 14. Hither. The next kinsman might otherwise allege this as a pretext for not marrying her, (Salien) as people are but too apt to suspect the worst, though nothing amiss had passed between them. H. - -- Booz consulted his own as well as Ruth's reputation: for the apostle admonishes us to abstain from every appearance of evil. 1 Thess. v. 22. M.

Ver. 15. Mantle. The Syrian and Arab. ladies cover themselves all over with a large white veil, or piece of cloth, which has no hole", so that Ruth might conveniently carry the barley in it. ---

Measures is not in Heb. or Sept. Most people supply ephi. S. Jerom, who has translated six bushels, (allowing three to the ephi; C. ii. 17,) has understood that Booz gave Ruth two ephi. If we explain it of six ephi, the burden would be great enough, consisting of 180 pints or pounds of barley. Bonfrere would supply six gomers, each of which consisted of only the tenth part of the ephi, or three pints, in all 18. But such a present seems too inconsiderable. We may therefore stick to S. Jerom, whose six measures (C.--- modios, bushels; H.) make about 60 pints; (C.) or, according to others, 160 pounds, which, though heavy, a woman might carry. The Sept. insinuate, that Ruth carried the barley in her apron. M. --- And. Heb. "he went. " But the text is probably corrupted. C.

Ver. 16. What, &c. Heb. "Who art thou?" It was yet so dark that she did not know her. C.

RUTH 4

CHAPTER IV.

Ver. 1. Gate, where justice was administered. --- Calling. Heb. Ploni Almoni. C.

--- Prot. " Ho!

such a one." H. --- This form of speech is used concerning a person whose name we know not, or will not mention. 1 K. xxi. 2. C. --- The name of this man is buried in eternal oblivion, perhaps because he was so much concerned about the splendour of his family, that he would not marry the widow of his deceased relation. T.

Ver. 2. Here, as witnesses, not as judges, v. 9. C. --- This number was requisite in matters of consequence. Grotius.

Ver. 3. Will sell. Some Latin copies read, "sells, or has sold." But the sequel shews that she was only now disposed to do it. But what right had Noemi or Ruth to the land, since women could not inherit? The latter might indeed retain her title, as long as she continued unmarried. But Noemi only acted in her behalf. Selden thinks that their respective husbands had made them a present of some land. Josephus (v. 11) asserts, that the person whom Booz addressed had already possession, and that he resigned his claim, as he would not take another wife. C. -- - Our brother.

He was his nephew, and calls him brother, as Abraham did Lot. W.

Ver. 4. This. Heb. "I thought to uncover thy ear," or to admonish thee. Virgil (frag.) uses a similar expression, Mors aurem vellens, vivite, ait, venio: "Death pulls the ear; live now, he says, I come." --- Not. Heb. printed erroneously, "But if he will not redeem it." Ken.

Ver. 5. When. Heb. again corruptly, "On the day thou buyest the land of the hand of Noemi, I will also buy it of Ruth," &c. It ought to be, conformably to some MSS. and the ancient versions,

"thou must also take Ruth," v. 10. Capel, p. 144, and 362. Kennicott. H. --- We see here the observance of two laws, the one preserving the inheritance in the same family, and the other obliging the next of kin to marry the widow of the deceased, if he would enjoy his land. Lev. xxv.

10. Deut. xxv. 5. C. --- Such widows as designed to comply with this condition, took possession of the land on the death of their husband, and conveyed it to those whom they married, till their eldest son became entitled to it. Abulensis, q. 30 to 61. --- Inheritance. The son to be born, would be esteemed the heir of his legal parent. M.

Ver. 6. Family. Heb. "I cannot redeem it for myself, lest I spoil my own inheritance." He was afraid of having too many children, and sensible that the first son that should be born of the proposed marriage, would not be counted as his. H. --- The miserable Onan had the same pretext.

Gen. xxxviii. 9. Chal. "Since I cannot make use of this privilege, having already a wife, and not being allowed to take another, as that might cause dissensions in my family, and spoil my inheritance, do thou redeem it,...as thou art unmarried."

Ver. 7. Israel. Heb. "and this was the testimony in Israel." The ceremony here specified is very different from that which the law prescribed. Deut. xxv. 7. But Josephus says, that they complied with all the regulations of the law, and that Ruth was present on this occasion. C. --- Perhaps the law was not executed in all its rigour, when another was found to marry the widow, (W.) and when no real brother was living. T.

Ver. 9. Chelion. As Orpha, his widow, took no care to comply with the law, all his possessions devolved on his brother's posterity. M. --- It was presumed that she would marry some Moabite.

C.

Ver. 10. Moabites. The sons of Elimelech were excused in taking such women to wife, on account of necessity, and to avoid the danger of incontinence, which is a greater evil. Booz was under another sort of necessity, and was bound to comply with the law; (C.) so that he was guilty of no sin, as Beza would pretend. T. --- Some also remark, that the exclusion of the people of Moab from the Church of God, regarded not the females, (S. Aug. q. 35, in Deut. Serar. T. &c.) particularly if they embraced the true religion. According to the Rabbins, Obed should have been accounted a Moabite, as they say children follow the condition of their mothers: but we need not here adopt their decisions. -- People. Heb. "and from the gate of his place." In the assemblies, the legal son of Mahalon would represent him, though he was also considered as the son of Booz, at least if the latter had no other, as was probably the case.

Ver. 11. Israel, by a numerous posterity. --- That she. Heb. "mayst thou acquire riches," &c. C.

--- Prot. "do thou (Booz) worthily in," &c. H. --- Ephrata: another name of Bethlehem. Ch.

Ver. 12. Phares. His family was chief among the five, descended from Juda. M.

Ver. 14. Successor. Heb. "redeemer, that his (Booz, or the Lord's) name," &c. C.

Ver. 15. Comfort. Heb. "to make thy soul revive."

Ver. 17. Obed; "serving," to comfort the old age of Noemi, (v. 15,) who gave him this' name.

(Serar. q. 14,) at the suggestion of her neighbours. M.

Ver. 18. These. Hence the design of the sacred writer becomes evident, (C.) to shew the genealogy of David, from whom Christ sprang, as it had been foretold. See Gen. xlix. Mat. i.

&c. W.

Ver. 19. Aram. He is called Ram in Heb. and 1 Par. ii. 9.

Ver. 20. Salmon. Heb. and Chal. Salma, (H.) though we read Salmon in the following verse. C.

--- This is one argument adduced by Houbigant, to shew that this genealogy is now imperfect. He concludes that Salma ought to be admitted, as well as Salmon; and, as the reason for calling the first son of Ruth, Obed, "serving or ploughing," seems rather harsh, as we should naturally expect some more glorious title. He thinks that the immediate son of Ruth was called Jachin, "he shall establish;" and that Solomon called one of the pillars before the temple by his name, as he did the other Booz, "in strength," in honour of his ancestors. Baz icin means, "In strength (or solidity) it (he) shall (stand or) establish." As the son of Booz established his father's house, (v. 10. 11,) so these pillars denoted the stability of the temple. We must thus allow that the hand of

time has mutilated the genealogy of David, and that two ought to be admitted among his ancestors, who have been here omitted, as S. Matthew likewise passes them over as well as three others, who were the descendants of Joram. The same omission of Jachin occurs 1 Paral. ii. 11, where we find Salma instead of Salmon. Houbigant supposes that the sacred writers, Esdras and S.

Matthew, gave the genealogies as they found them, without correcting the mistakes of transcribers. Chronolog. sacra, p. 81. But there might be some reason for the omission which we do not know; and Nahasson, Booz, and Joram might be said to beget Salmon, Obed, and Jechonias, though they were not their immediate children. Salien and many others assert, that there were three of the name of Booz, succeeding each other, so that six persons instead of four fill up the space of 440 years, from the taking of Jericho till the building of the temple. Salien, A.

2741, in which year he places the birth of the third Booz, who married Ruth, seventy years afterwards. Petau allows 520 years from the coming out of Egypt till the fourth year of Solomon, so that he leaves above 420 years to the three generations of Booz, Obed, and Isai. But he prudently passes over this chronological difficulty. Usher supposes that each of these people were almost 100 years old when they had children; and he produces many examples of people who lived beyond that age, but he does not mention any, since the days of Moses, who had children at such an advanced age, much less that many in the same family, and in succession, were remarkable for such a thing.

Moreover, according to Houbigant's chronology, Booz and Obed must have had children when they were almost 120, and Isai in his 107th year. But by admitting Salma and Jachin, the five persons might each have sons when they were about seventy, and thus would complete 347 years. See C. ii. 1. H.

Ver. 22. David, the king, whom Samuel crowned, though he did not live to see him in the full enjoyment of his power, (H.) as he died before Saul. C. --- Thus the greatest personages have people of mean condition among their ancestors, that none may be too much elated on account of their high birth.

Ruth, notwithstanding her poverty, was a striking figure of the Christian Church.

H. --- The Gentiles were strangers to Christ, on account of their errors, but related to him in as much as they were his creatures. Their miserable condition pleaded hard for them, that Jesus would receive them under his protection, espouse and give them rest and peace. Booz would, not marry Ruth till the nearer relation had refused, and thus brought dishonour on himself; (Deut.

xxv.) so Jesus was principally sent to the lost sheep of the house of Israel, and did not send his apostles to the Gentiles till the Jews had rejected their ministry. C. --- See S. Amb. de fide, iii. 5.

D. --- Ruth was also a pattern of the most perfect virtues. See Louis de Puente.

T.